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From the editor-in-chief

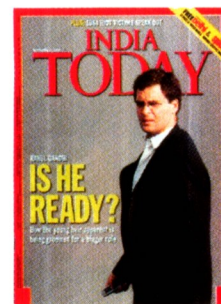
This may well go down as a transformational moment in Indian politics. In the course of just a few days, Rahul Gandhi has grabbed centrestage in Congress politics and given evidence that far from being just a cute-looking campaigner with a famous last name, he could also be the game changer. Suddenly he is everywhere, having almost overnight shed the image of a reluctant crown prince, the reticent, reclusive first-time MP. Instead, he is in the vanguard of the Congress campaign, leading the charge, assertive, confident, open, even statesmanlike in his utterances, holding forth on everything from post-election alliances to the Bofors scandal, the rich-poor divide and the economy at a series of meetings with the media, an entity he normally avoided like, well, swine flu.

It's a remarkable transformation and marks the emergence of a new Rahul Gandhi, a confident young unconventional leader with a left of centre ideology appealing to a new breed of voter. His praise of the Congress party's political rivals like Nitish Kumar, Chandrababu Naidu and even his conciliatory noises for the Left have upset allies and caused much consternation within the UPA. Yet, it carries a new conviction, perhaps in the realisation that this is Rahul's defining moment, his war, his campaign, and a strategic decision to project Rahul more forcefully in an election where youth below 25 constitute approximately 40 per cent of the electorate.

He still talks of Manmohan Singh as "my prime minister" and his mother Sonia Gandhi as "my boss". Yet, there is no question that he has been given the freedom to defy the established hierarchy in the party and articulate his stand even if it contradicts the official line. He has pushed everyone else into the background and assumed the role of chief campaigner, chief spokesman, chief conscience-keeper, chief Rottweiler, and key political strategist, attacking the BJP's weaknesses and leaving the door open for possible future alliances post May 16.

He has so far addressed 102 meetings in 97 constituencies, more than any other Congress leader including his "boss", who is party president and chairperson of the UPA. More important, his voice is his own, sometimes inconsistent with flashes of naivete, but his answers to tricky questions are spontaneous and forceful, and he now has a message to convey along with the new aggressiveness. In the process, he has turned this election into his own. He has also shown a new maturity and sense of responsibility, missing so far. The Rahul offensive is, however, also one that carries an element of risk. If the party does badly in the elections, his high-profile role will be seen as a negative.

Ultimately, however, he belongs to the world's most durable dynasty. Like his late father, Rahul has an innate charm emboldened by an attractive personality and looks. What he lacked was political maturity and a clearly defined role. He has both now and there is no turning back. Back in September 2005, we had put him on the cover and asked the question: Is He Ready? We now have the answer.



OUR SEPTEMBER
2005 COVER

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)